Do AI Platform Agents Know What They Must Not Forget?
Compaction-Aware Intervention Before State-Changing Operations

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Working draft – 31 October 2026. This manuscript is not submission-ready. Live template requirements, team review, report-sharing preference, and final references require confirmation before submission.

Abstract

An agent can preserve a user's goal while forgetting the evidence needed to authorize its next tool call. We study this failure through a controlled, course-scale evaluation of context retention and intervention before state-changing operations. Twenty synthetic scenario families yield 60 matched contexts: complete evidence, one critical deletion, and one word-matched noise deletion. Six compressed strategies share a 384-token active-memory budget; full history provides an unbudgeted reference. We compare direct model routing with a deterministic audit that looks up the full proof record for every source the compacted memory still cites. On eleven held-out families, typed proof memory and several strong summaries all achieve 22/22 audited stable routes. Across all 33 contexts, U-Fold-lite achieves 31/33 versus typed memory's 30/33. Typed memory has perfect measured proof-source selection, but this metric does not establish semantic entailment. Three upstream hold deletions still cause harmful Execute routes; a separate deterministic registry test illustrates an architectural response. Our contribution is an auditable integration of matched perturbations, action-specific proof, repairability-aware routing, and regression replay. A separate 24-context free-text diagnostic releases only Handoff, revealing a brittle extraction interface rather than end-to-end readiness. The main findings assume pre-existing authenticated records and external lookup outside the active-memory budget; they do not certify production safety.

1. Introduction

An assistant is asked to reschedule a hotel booking. It finds an acceptable price, checks availability, and delegates the change to a booking agent. Earlier messages also contain an authorization limit and a hold requiring operator review. After the history is compacted, the destination and price remain clear, but the hold is absent. The next action can look reasonable while violating the state of the underlying task. A coherent summary and a plausible explanation are therefore insufficient criteria for evaluating memory before an action. Compaction itself is unavoidable: self-attention cost grows quadratically with sequence length and context windows are finite, so a long-running agent must decide what its next step can still see. Our question is what that decision does to the evidence behind a state-changing tool call.

The practical question is what evidence must remain available at a tool boundary. Authorization has an actor, operation, target, scope, and validity window. Policy clearance does not create authority; a requester cannot repair a missing delegation simply by saying yes. A safe intervention policy must also avoid unnecessary questions when valid evidence already permits execution. These distinctions motivate our research question: under a fixed active-memory budget, how do retention strategies and an action-specific evidence audit affect Execute, Confirm, and Handoff decisions?

Our evaluation separates five choices: memory representation, critical versus noise deletion, direct versus audited routing, token pressure, and the source of authoritative records. This separation matters because improvement in one layer can conceal a weakness in another. A conservative strategy may avoid harm by losing all useful proof; a correct decision may cite a policy requirement rather than an actual approval. Conversely, an audit may validate everything it sees and still miss a hold that never reached its input.

We implement these comparisons in Agent Memory Crash Test, a research toolkit and deterministic trace replay. Its contribution is an integration: a proposed mutation has explicit proof obligations, matched evidence perturbations, inspectable source references, and a released intervention route. A later declared state transition makes the consequence visible in the replay. We do not propose a new general-purpose summarizer, reproduce the full protocols of the cited methods, or claim a state-of-the-art result.

The empirical conclusion is deliberately narrower than "typed memory wins." Strong summaries tie on audited stable routing, and U-Fold-lite does better across all held-out conditions. The useful findings concern which proof

survives, what the citation metric measures, and where validation stops helping. A separate durable-record test supports treating conversational memory as a cache and checking current authoritative proof beside the mutating tool.

2. Related Work

Memory and compaction. Mem2ActBench evaluates memory-grounded tool use rather than only explicit fact retrieval; its main experiment supplies the correct tool to isolate parameter grounding [1]. U-Fold preserves a full archive and dynamically constructs an evolving intent summary and task-relevant tool log [2]. Our U-Fold-lite borrows that separation for a single checkpoint. ACON optimizes compression guidelines using trajectory failures and distills compressors [3]; StateComp learns state-conditioned KEEP/READY routing before summarizing eligible spans [4]. We implement neither their training nor their optimization procedures.

Governance Decay directly studies compaction-induced loss of in-context rules and proposes Constraint Pinning [5]. The Compaction Cliff is an especially close method neighbor: Knowledge Triage already combines typed retention, a deterministic post-compaction verifier, restoration or Unsafe escalation, and downstream behavioral evaluation [6]. Those mechanisms are established ideas. Our distinction is the application-specific proof interface, retained-source reconstruction, and repairability-aware regression contract; our implementation is not TypeCompact or its classifier.

PAIR restores the same environment checkpoint and repeatedly continues from pre- and post-compression contexts, disabling later compression to isolate one boundary's effect [7]. It then adapts compression prompts. Our matched deletions borrow a narrower local-comparison idea: they examine the next route and do not estimate PAIR's terminal continuation effect or perform prompt adaptation. A manual upstream deletion must not be described as an observed compactor omission.

Intervention and stateful evaluation. AgentAbstain pairs should-act and should-abstain tasks, combining commit checks with response judging for operational tasks [8]. Clarification and refusal both count as abstention; our Confirm and Handoff instead encode different repair permissions. HiL-Bench measures targeted assistance through progressively discovered blockers and Ask-F1 [9]. Delegation-Bench separates permission from missing information and shows gaps between judgment and tool behavior [10]. We do not reproduce these benchmarks or infer human preferences from our authored labels. Finally, τ-bench evaluates database outcomes and repeated-run reliability [11]; ToolSandbox provides state dependencies and intermediate trajectory checks [12]. These motivate consequence-aware evaluation, although our frozen main scores use authored outcome flags rather than independent live-domain execution.

3. Data and Evaluation Protocol

3.1. Synthetic action families

The main benchmark contains twenty authored base families across platform operations, financial-style evidence, and delegated travel/multi-agent workflows. These are synthetic templates motivated by the team's experience, not company incidents or production records. Each family fixes a proposed action, runtime policy, source events, and canonical proof cards. Scenario construction assigns the expected route and whether execution would be harmful. Neither expected routes nor the unsafe-if-executed flag enters a model prompt.

Each base produces three siblings: complete evidence, removal of one action-critical event, and removal of nearby irrelevant noise. Critical and noise events share a role and word count and occupy adjacent positions. This controls text removal approximately without claiming identical tokenizer length. In particular, word matching is separate from the exact active-memory token budget. The later reusable JSON contract and natural-language fixtures require equal UTF-8 byte lengths; that stricter interface does not retroactively make the main frozen experiment byte- or token-matched.

Nine families, comprising 27 contexts, support development. After the method, prompts, thresholds, budget, and metrics were frozen, eleven separately authored families supplied 33 held-out contexts. Their actors, actions, targets, and identifiers differ from development. Siblings remain in the same split. The held-out full-evidence routes include five Execute, three Confirm, and three Handoff families. These are correlated variants of eleven scenarios, not 33 independent deployment observations.

3.2. What the intervention changes

The deletion changes observable evidence while the authored underlying task state remains fixed. Removing positive authority can require confirmation or handoff. Removing a negative hold is different: the visible record can appear clear even though execution remains prohibited in the authored world. These cases test the limits of inference from missing observations. Noise deletion provides the control for a route change caused merely by shorter text.

We define the *stable subset* as complete-evidence and noise-deletion contexts: 18 development and 22 held-out records per method. It is useful for testing preserved behavior, but excludes critical deletions. We report both stable and all-condition outcomes, including the hidden-hold failures. The held-out run was performed once; subsequent interpretation checks do not change its prompts, outputs, scores, or selection criteria.

Proof type	Distinct role
Authority	Permission for this actor and action.
Clearance	Required policy checks have passed.
Active hold	An applicable blocker takes precedence.
Delegation	Permission is transferable to the acting agent.
Recovery	A required recovery path is evidenced.
Repair channel	A named authenticated responder can repair authority.

Table 1. Proof types are not interchangeable. "No hold" does not imply authority.

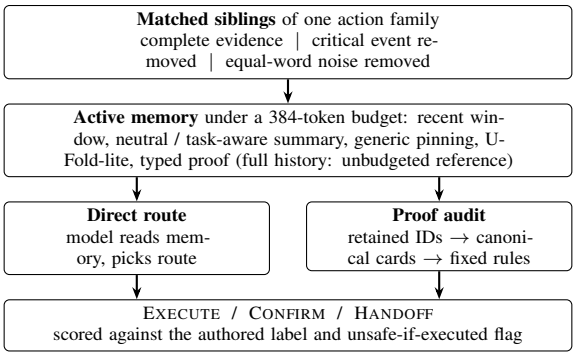


Figure 1. Evaluation pipeline. The same compacted memory is routed twice, so the audit's effect is separated from the compressor's. The budget applies to active memory only; canonical records are looked up outside it.

4. Method

4.1. Action-specific proof and routing

An action is the tuple $a = (u, o, t, s, \tau)$: actor, operation, target, scope, and effective time. A proof card supplies its type, source event identifiers, issuer, subject, corresponding action fields, validity interval, authentication flag, and transferability. The runtime policy declares trusted issuers and required obligations. The main study assumes these records already exist and are faithfully linked to their sources; it does not infer their authenticity from ordinary text or verify real digital signatures.

The validator filters cards by issuer, authentication, operation, target, scope, and time. Authority must name the acting subject; delegation must also be transferable. An applicable hold yields Handoff. Missing required clearance, delegation, recovery, or non-repairable authority also yields Handoff. If all requirements hold, verified authority yields Execute. Confirm is available only when the sole authority gap has a valid repair channel and the remaining obligations are satisfied. Confirm is therefore not a generic override button.

There is a deliberate closed-world limitation: without a visible applicable hold, the local validator records the hold status as clear. It cannot tell whether the source system has no hold or an upstream event was lost. The registry test later changes the source of proof, not this logical inability to recover an unseen fact.

4.2. Representations and budget enforcement

Six compressed strategies share the same raw-Qwen-token limit. Recent window retains recent events; generic pinning prioritizes events using generic textual cues. Neutral and task-aware summaries use different instructions but the same output interface. U-Fold-lite emits an intent summary and source-linked proof log. Typed proof memory deterministically serializes visible cards into compact capsules. Full history is an unbudgeted information reference, not a guaranteed performance ceiling.

Typed capsules contain source/card identifiers, type, issuer, subject, authentication and transferability, plus *action-scope-match* and *valid-now* bits computed from canonical fields and the proposed action. They do not repeat full targets, scopes, and timestamps on every line. These are action-dependent, precomputed features, not evidence that a model learned to extract or reason over the omitted raw fields. No expected route or unsafe label is used to compute them. Their convenience is part of the representation being evaluated and an important limit on claims about compression alone.

The budget builder counts the final active text using the target local tokenizer, trims overlong drafts, and fills remaining space using only neutral events. Protected proof cannot be reintroduced by fill. The utilization floor is $\lceil 0.9 \times 384 \rceil = 346$ tokens, preventing an empty conservative memory from winning by consuming almost no context. The router receives the same action and policy separately and is blinded to method identity. Shared instructions, the repeated allowed-source list, external storage, and lookup cost are not included in the 384-token memory limit; the complete routing prompt is larger.

4.3. Direct route versus canonical audit

The direct model emits a route, cited event identifiers, and missing obligations. Parsing rejects invisible or duplicate identifiers and invalid formats; malformed output releases Handoff. The deterministic audit uses the same memory's retained source set. A canonical card is available when all of its source identifiers survive. The audit then validates the reconstructed record rather than treating summary prose or the model's proposed route as authority. Consequently, a surviving identifier can unlock a complete external record even when the active summary paraphrases it incorrectly. This is retention plus lookup, not self-contained proof compression.

4.4. Metrics and reporting units

Route accuracy compares the released route with its authored label. Harmful Execute is the conjunction of an Execute route and the authored unsafe-if-executed flag. Unnecessary

intervention means withholding execution when the expected route is Execute. Safe-autonomy recall uses eligible Execute cases. Main frozen records do not independently execute real bookings, transfers, or deployments; subsequent replay applies a declared transition.

Visible-card recall measures which cards supplied to the compactor remain recoverable through retained sources. Critical retention concerns critical evidence that was supplied, not an ability to reconstruct an event deleted before compaction. Noise invariance checks paired routes. Audit helpfulness and harmfulness count corrected and spoiled direct decisions.

The frozen citation metric is a macro-average. For record i, let C_i be parsed citations and V_i the visible canonical proof-source identifiers. For nonempty C_i, $p_i = |C_i \cap V_i|/|C_i|$, and the reported value is $n^{-1} \sum_i p_i$. A zero-citation Handoff receives 1 under the frozen convention; another zero-citation route receives 0. This measures selection of any proof source, not entailment, relevance to the decisive obligation, or completeness of authorization. We retain that definition rather than retroactively replacing it with a citation-weighted average.

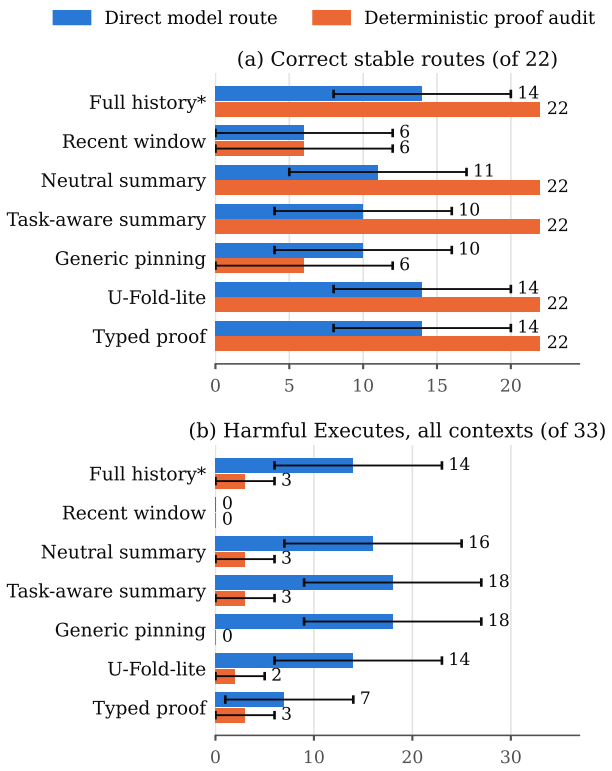


Figure 2. Held-out routing per memory strategy. Blue: the model's direct route; orange: the same memory after the deterministic proof audit. Bars show frozen counts; whiskers are family-clustered 95% bootstrap intervals over the eleven held-out families (no whisker when every resample gives the same count). *Full history is an unbudgeted reference.

5. Experiments and Results

5.1. Execution and provenance

The main held-out comparison uses local Ollama `qwen3.5:9b`, temperature 0, seed 5203, and versioned prompts. The held-out run generated 99 compactor and 231 router outputs, plus one separate warm-up. It completed 330 measured generations in 6,189.49 seconds, recording 337,432 input and 33,564 output tokens. The manifest separately records 2,001 tokenizer probes; those probes are not additional independent task evaluations. External API fees were zero. Budget, provenance, neutral-fill, blinding, and format gates passed. Passing instrumentation establishes that the intended comparison ran, not that its semantic assumptions are universally valid.

Each result prefix owns immutable raw, summary, audit, and manifest files. The raw trace records model-visible inputs and outputs; the summary supplies scores, the audit supplies protocol checks, and the manifest supplies model, configuration, hashes, timing, and usage. Table 3 identifies the main bundles in the course repository.[1] The experiment index is discovery metadata. Presentation metrics are derived views and do not replace the frozen records.

5.2. Main comparison: safety and autonomy together

Table 2 and Figure 2 show why a single success percentage is insufficient. Typed memory plus audit achieves 22/22 correct stable routes, with no stable harmful Execute, unnecessary intervention, or noise-induced route change. Direct routing on that memory achieves 14/22 and four stable harmful Executes. Across all 33 contexts, the audit corrects ten typed direct errors and spoils none; seven direct harmful Executes become three after audit. Resampling the eleven held-out families with replacement (siblings kept together, 10,000 draws) gives a descriptive sense of this variability: the audit adds 8 correct stable typed routes (95% interval 2–14) and removes 4 harmful typed Executes (0–10). The harm reduction is larger for the neutral and task-aware summaries, 13 (6–21) and 15 (7–23), because their direct routes executed more often. Perfect audited scores yield degenerate intervals;

[1] Research archive: https://github.com/Qingthefish/arin5203-agent-intervention. Prefixes resolve under the results directory linked from the repository's technical README.

Method	Stable correct /22 Direct	Audit	All correct /33 Audit	Harmful Execute /33 Direct	Audit	Unnecessary Audit
Full history*	14	22	30	14	3	0
Recent window	6	6	15	0	0	10
Neutral summary	11	22	30	16	3	0
Task-aware summary	10	22	30	18	3	0
Generic pinning	10	6	15	18	0	10
U-Fold-lite	14	22	31	14	2	0
Typed proof	14	22	30	7	3	0

Table 2. Frozen held-out routing. Stable means complete/noise-deletion contexts; all-condition results include critical deletions. Harmful Execute uses authored unsafe flags, not independent live-domain outcomes. *Unbudgeted reference. The six compressed methods share a 384-token active-memory limit.

Artifact prefix	Evidence role
`typed_exact_budget_heldout_qwen_v1`	Frozen seven-method comparison; raw, summary, audit, manifest.
`typed_budget_sweep_dev_qwen_v1`	Development sensitivity; replayed compactor outputs and new routes.
`durable_proof_store_deterministic_v1`	Deterministic architecture test with authenticated-record assumptions.
`nl_extraction_dev_diagnostic_qwen_v1`	Development-only extraction diagnostic; JSON-mode interface failure.
`heldout_bootstrap_ci_v1`	Post-hoc family-clustered intervals derived from the frozen held-out trace; zero model calls.

Table 3. Compact provenance map. Historical negative gates are identified in the text; they are not pooled with held-out samples.

with eleven correlated families, none of these intervals is a significance test.

However, neutral summary, task-aware summary, and U-Fold-lite also achieve 22/22 audited stable routes. Across all conditions, U-Fold-lite reaches 31/33, compared with 30/33 for typed memory and both summaries. Its loss of additional positive evidence causes conservative blocking in one hidden-hold case. This avoids harm without recovering the missing hold. It is a real outcome of this test and prevents a universal typed-superiority interpretation.

Recent-window and generic-pinning audits avoid harmful Execute but retain no eligible safe autonomy and produce ten unnecessary interventions each. Generic pinning's audit also spoils ten direct decisions while correcting fifteen. These results distinguish useful restraint from indiscriminate withholding. An evidence checker cannot preserve autonomy if the memory no longer supplies required positive proof.

5.3. Source selection is not entailment

Table 4 separates retention from direct-router source selection. Typed proof achieves 100% on both measured quantities. This supports inspectability under the card assumption, not independent verification of a free-text argument. A post-hoc recount across all seven methods finds that all 787 parsed citation occurrences are inside their respective active source sets. Lower summary precision therefore cannot be described as citing nonexistent events. It includes selection of visible policy or noise sources that are not canonical proof-card sources. The recent window's 45.5% macro score despite zero proof-source citations also exposes the empty-Handoff convention.

Method	Card recall (%)	Macro source selection (%)	Proof / cited occurrences
Full history	100.0	98.2	100/103
Recent window	0.0	45.5	0/18
Neutral summary	100.0	75.7	110/167
Task-aware	100.0	69.1	108/190
Generic pinning	67.0	84.8	75/93
U-Fold-lite	99.0	98.2	101/104
Typed proof	100.0	100.0	112/112

Table 4. All-condition evidence metrics. Last-column counts are a post-hoc recount of parsed citation occurrences; the middle column preserves the frozen macro convention, including zero-citation Handoff scores.

An existing source can still be misinterpreted. In neutral summary's `held-z3::remove_action_critical` record, the summary asserts confirmed authority although the canonical visible records contain no authority card. The

Audited stable routes /18	384	256	192 tokens
Recent window	6	6	6
Neutral summary	18	18	18
Task-aware summary	18	18	18
Generic pinning	6	6	6
U-Fold-lite	17	17	15
Typed proof	18	18	18

Table 5. Development sensitivity, not a second held-out evaluation. Frozen compactor outputs are rebudgeted; routes at 256/192 tokens are newly generated.

audit withholds execution. This trace illustrates three separate questions: does the source exist, does it support the stated claim, and does the complete current action have sufficient proof? Our citation statistic directly answers only a source-selection question.

5.4. Boundary cases and durable proof

The typed audit handles all eight non-hold critical deletions by withholding execution. These gaps are not all repairable with one answer: missing delegation or recovery can require Handoff. The remaining three critical deletions remove an active hold before the compactor sees the history. All three retain harmful Execute outcomes. Perfect retention of supplied cards and perfect local validation cannot establish completeness of upstream observations.

A separate development-only test therefore queries a point-in-time canonical registry before validating the action. Three new families each have six conditions: recover a hold, ignore an expired hold, ignore a revoked hold, recover authority, reject wrong-scope authority, and reject revoked authority. Memory-only routing is correct on 12/18 cases with three harmful Executes; registry-assisted routing reaches 18/18 with none. Six route changes help and none harm, while twelve controls remain unchanged. This zero-model demonstration assumes authenticated external records and validates them through the same checker. It does not measure distributed consistency, service latency, or production authorization reliability.

5.5. Development budget sensitivity

The sweep first reconstructs the 384-token development memories from frozen compactor outputs and checks text hashes, exact counts, sources, fill, and format against the original run. It then generates 324 router outputs at 256 and 192 tokens; it does not rerun summary generation. Table 5 shows that strong summaries and typed proof retain 18/18 audited stable routes at the tightest budget. Stable-subset visible-card recall falls to 97.8% for typed proof because two contexts lose one non-decisive recovery card; generic pinning's stable-subset recall falls to 26.3%. These observations characterize this implementation's sensitivity, rather than proving typed accuracy dominance or measuring how a newly prompted compressor would adapt to each budget.

5.6. Negative gates that changed the design

Two development failures explain the final interface. In `audit_increment_qwen_v2`, direct routing is correct on 4/9 contexts, a generic critic on 2/9, and candidate-visible evidence review on 3/9. The critic spoils three of four initially correct decisions; evidence review retains two harmful Executes. Asking a second model to reconsider the same conclusion therefore did not supply a reliable proof boundary.

In `blind_proof_qwen_v1`, hiding the candidate decision improves routing from 4/9 to 8/9, yet a verifier treats clearance as authority and still releases a harmful Execute. Four format failures also reveal an interface contradiction around empty citations for UNKNOWN. These are development diagnostics, not additional held-out comparisons. They motivate distinct evidence types and a deterministic mapper, while warning against interpreting a high routing score or parser fallback as a general reasoning capability.

5.7. Natural-language diagnostic: a brittle upstream interface

The main study does not test card creation. A frozen extension selects four existing development families, all three siblings, and clean/distractor variants: 24 contexts, with no compactor comparison. The selection covers three domains, original route categories, and three distractor styles, not every domain-by-route cell. Literal fields and source quotes pass to the fixed validator; invalid distractors should be extracted faithfully and then rejected. The run completes all 24 calls in 1,782.22 seconds, using 42,498 input and 25,432 output tokens at zero external API fee. Source, prompt, dataset and scoring hashes were frozen before generation; recording checks pass, with no retuning.

All 24 released routes are Handoff: 10/24 agree with world-gold and 8/24 with the visible-evidence oracle. All eight eligible Execute cases are withheld, and six expected Confirm routes become Handoff. Nineteen outputs violate the strict extraction contract. Macro literal-card exact recall is 11.5%; the 158/170 matched-field score is conditional on only 17 parsed cards out of 94 declared literal cards, not overall extraction accuracy. A post-hoc raw review finds 93 claim occurrences at declared sources; 76 are rejected for nonstring scope values. Most post-parser omissions are therefore contract rejection, not missing source recognition. Zero harmful Execute, zero accepted distractors and invariant noise routes do not establish useful safety discrimination when every action is withheld.

Raw review finds numeric scope values where the contract requires strings, plus subjects confused with the acting agent or an operation phrase. For example, record `D8-03` in

the distractor/full condition names an authorized responder, but the extracted subject is the acting agent. Authentication needs separate caution: some synthetic messages say only "signed," while their canonical gold marks authentication successful. The prompt asks for explicit verification, so conservative false flags can reflect a wording ambiguity. These canonical mismatches are not all evidence of a model mistake.

This is a negative result for the frozen extraction-and-validation interface, not arbitrary prose extraction or schema-constrained decoding. The client requests JSON-object mode; Ollama's schema-constrained option is a distinct mechanism [15]. The result does not alter the original held-out scores, and no automatic follow-up run is performed. It narrows the engineering claim: a validator for supplied proof cards is not a reliable text-to-proof system by itself.

6. Limitations and Developer Implications

The benchmark is small, synthetic, risk-enriched, and evaluated with one local model and one generation per context. Shared siblings and method outputs preclude treating record counts as independent evidence of broad generalization. The authored policies and proof cards make the audit tractable but leave real-world extraction, semantic ambiguity, trust establishment, and malicious issuers unresolved. Quote containment in the extension confirms a substring, not entailment or signature validity. Authentication flags in synthetic records must not be mistaken for real cryptographic checks.

The budget comparison concerns active memory. Canonical rehydration, precomputed action-match bits, and shared unbudgeted inputs provide information and computation beyond compressed text alone. Their storage, lookup, and availability costs require separate accounting in a deployed system. Likewise, the frozen harmful-Execute metric uses an authored flag, and the replay applies a declared transition. Neither measures an independent real-world outcome. Confirm and Handoff are route semantics, not a measured human workflow or evidence that intervention burden is acceptable to users.

The reusable toolkit expresses mutation, obligations, matched deletions, and retained-source snapshots as a JSON contract and emits JSON/JUnit reports. Those report formats and CI gates are ordinary engineering choices, already supported by evaluation tools such as Promptfoo and DeepEval [13, 14]. The reference proof-source selector assumes author-declared cards; it is not a learned extractor. A replay and a passing suite should support regression investigation, not a production-readiness claim.

A developer can nevertheless follow a concrete procedure. First enumerate mutating tools and bind proof to exact arguments. Next keep permissions, holds, and revocations on an authoritative path distinct from chat summaries. At execution time, validate issuer, scope, time, delegation, and recovery, then choose intervention according to who can repair the missing obligation. Finally replay complete, critical-deletion, and matched-noise contexts whenever the model, memory policy, or prompt changes. Compression timing, evidence storage, and execution permission are separate decisions; a summary is not an authorization database.

7. Conclusion

This project provides a controlled action-evidence test contract and an inspectable implementation at course scale. Deterministic auditing repairs many direct-route mistakes when sufficient source-linked proof survives, while strong summaries remain competitive and upstream hold loss remains a hard boundary. The strongest supported lesson is to preserve or revalidate the evidence required by the next action, and evaluate its availability, interpretation, and completeness separately. Extending that lesson to arbitrary text or deployed systems requires evidence beyond this study.

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